Polity · MF-I Mains Master Map

Seq 34 · Sat 14 Nov 2026

Institutions · Federal & local · Judiciary & tribunals · Accountability & elections · Rights, design, comparison · Answer error · Chips: Mains Qs 2013–26 · hot = 3+ since 2022 or asked 2026

The spine of every answer

D · Definition — what it is, one line

W · Why — purpose, the framers' intent

B · Basis — Article + case

H · How — how it works

G · Gains — record, with evidence

G · Gaps — three, with evidence

R · Reforms — mechanism · institution · accountability

J · Judgement — balanced verdict

① Institutions

Parliament · Governor · executive

T6: 16 Qs · last 2024 · hot · T3: 4 Qs · last 2026 · hot

Parliament (T6): powers intact, habit lost — the 17th Lok Sabha sat 274 days; bills sent to committees fell 60% → 71% → 27% → 16% (14th–17th LS, PRS); Deputy Speaker vacant 2019–24; Money Bill route.

Reform: minimum sittings (NCRWC 120 / 100) · default committee referral unless the Speaker records reasons · whips only for confidence and Money Bills (LC 170th).

Governor (T3): constitutional head on advice (Shamsher Singh 1974); discretion narrow (Nabam Rebia 2016); not removable arbitrarily (B.P. Singhal 2010); **Art. 200 has no deadline — 20 Nov 2025: no court timelines, no deemed assent.**

Reform: amend Art. 200 for a time limit (Punchhi) · code of conduct via the ISC · consult the CM on appointment (Sarkaria).

Judgement lines: 'Parliament has not lost its powers; it has lost the habit of using them.' · 'A sentinel, not a parallel government.'

② Federalism & local government

T2: 16 Qs · last 2026 · hot · T1: 11 Qs · last 2026 · hot

Federalism (T2): Union of States (Art. 1); quasi-federal (Wheare), cooperative (Austin); Bommai made federalism basic and Art. 356 reviewable; FC devolution 42% (14th) → 41% (15th); strains: cesses outside the pool, Governors, agency consent, delimitation.

Reform: cap cesses (Arts. 270–271) · a standing ISC with a secretariat (Punchhi) · Governors appointed after consulting the CM.

Local (T1): the 73rd/74th created the tier; the 3Fs gap keeps it hollow — functions, funds, functionaries; parastatals; weak mayors; SFCs ignored; Gawali 2021 triple test, Suresh Mahajan 2022 polls.

Reform: statutory activity mapping · FC grants tied to audited accounts and property tax · directly elected mayors with fixed terms.

⑥ Verbs, openers, closers

44 of 134 begin with 'Discuss'

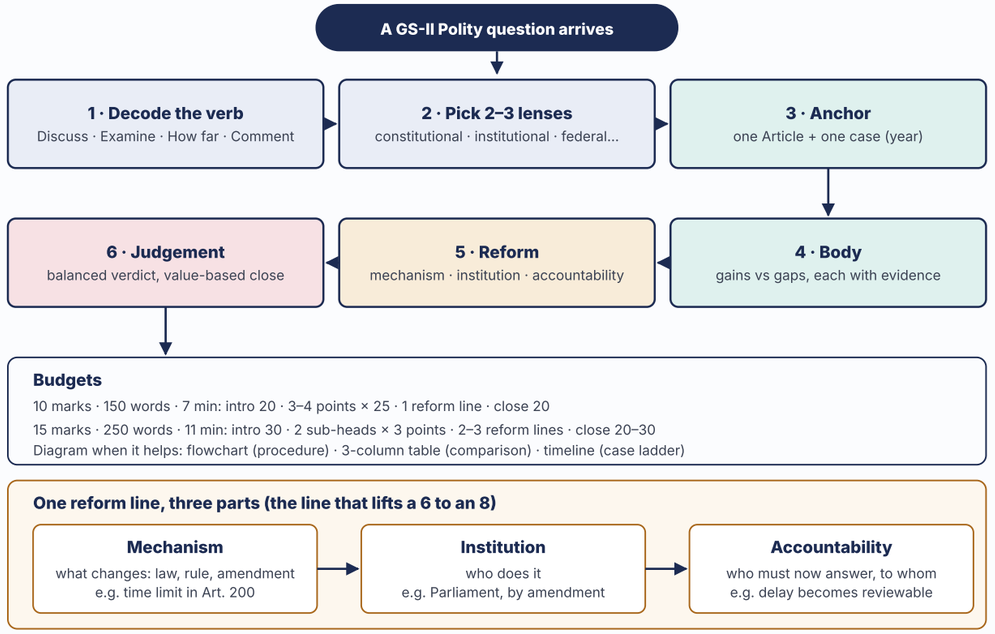
Verb	Shape
Discuss	both sides → verdict
Examine	factor by factor, each proved
Critically	merits, demerits, weighted verdict
How far / extent	degree first: 'largely, but…'
Comment	position first, then reasons
Suggest	three-part reform lines
Compare	same axes for both, as a table

Open with: a definition · an Article · a data point · a case · a 2025–26 event.

Close with: a constitutional value · a committee's fix · a forward line ('trust, not new powers…').

★ From question to answer in seven minutes

Hero diagram · the same engine for all 13 themes



Answer errors that cost marks

Timelines ≠ Sarkaria — Time limits for assent are Punchhi's; Sarkaria is about Art. 356 and the choice of Governors.

'Deemed assent' is gone — The April 2025 idea was rejected on 20 Nov 2025; do not cite it as law.

Right to vote — Statutory (Jyoti Basu, Kuldip Nayar); casting it is expression under 19(1)(a) (PUCL 2003).

Collegium is case law — Not in the text: 1993 and 1998 cases; NJAC struck in 2015.

ONOE is still a Bill — The 129th Amendment Bill is with the JPC; Kovind report 2024.

106th not yet live — Women's reservation awaits census and delimitation; the 131st Bill failed (Apr 2026).

Tribunals, 2025 — The 2021 Act's tenure and age bar were struck (19 Nov 2025); NTC ordered.

Speaker's 3 months — A judicial benchmark (Meghachandra, Telangana 2025), not text.

⑤ Rights, design, comparison, parties

T10 · T11 · T12 · T13

T10: 12 Qs · last 2026 · hot · T12: 9 Qs · last 2026 · hot · T11: 5 Qs · last 2025 · T13: 9 Qs · last 2026 · hot

Rights (T10)

Gopalan 1950 → Cooper 1970 → **Maneka 1978** → Olga Tellis 1985 → Vishaka 1997 → NALSA 2014 → **Puttaswamy 2017** → Navtej, Common Cause 2018 → Ranjitsinh 2024. The 2026 Transgender amendment vs self-identification (Mains 2026).

Amending power (T11)

Procedural limits: special majority, ratification, no joint sitting, assent. Substantive: basic structure (Kesavananda), limited power (Minerva), Coelho, NJAC. Proof the check works: **the 131st Bill failed, Apr 2026**.

Comparison (T12) · Parties (T13)

Compare on axes: executive, separation, judicial review, amendment, federalism, secularism, pardon, appointments.

Pressure groups: Almond–Powell; farm laws repealed 2021; no lobbying law; the CIC's 2013 order on parties unenforced.

③ Judiciary & tribunals

independence vs accountability

T4: 5 Qs · last 2025 · hot · T5: 5 Qs · last 2026 · hot · T8: 10 Qs · last 2025 · hot

Independence (T4): secured — collegium (1993, 1998), NJAC struck 2015. **Accountability** lags: MoP pending; no judge ever removed; **Justice Varma resigned in Apr 2026 before the inquiry found the charges proved**.

Reform: finalise the MoP with timelines · amend the Judges (Inquiry) Act so resignation does not end an inquiry · cooling-off before post-retirement posts.

Review & PIL (T5): checks and balances (Ram Jawaya Kapur 1955); guidelines — Vishaka, D.K. Basu, Prakash Singh, Common Cause; Art. 142 has limits (2025).

Tribunals (T8): L. Chandra Kumar 1997; the Madras Bar series to 19 Nov 2025; NTC; a 2026 Bill passed the LS (Aug).

④ Accountability bodies & elections

T9 is the largest mark pool

T9: 20 Qs · last 2026 · hot · T7: 12 Qs · last 2026 · hot

Bodies (T9): CAG legality and propriety (Mains 2024); FC; NCSC/NCST enforcement (2026); NCBC by the 102nd, states' lists restored by the 105th; NHRC recommendatory; CIC weakened 2019 and by DPDP 2023; constitutionalising a body needs an Art. 368 amendment.

Reform: findings binding unless rejected with reasons · tenure in the statute · a permanent FC secretariat.

Elections (T7): free and fair elections are basic (Raj Narain); ECI panel without the CJI (2023 Act); 46% of 2024 MPs declared criminal cases (ADR); bonds struck 2024; roll revision and citizenship (Lal Babu Hussein 1995).

Reform: an independent tribunal for defections (Goswami 1990, Telangana 2025) · the CJI on the ECI panel (LC 255th) · disqualification at charge-framing for serious crimes (LC 244th).

⑦ One case per theme

cite with the year

T1	Gawali 2021	triple test for OBC local seats
T2	Bommai 1994	356 reviewable; federalism basic
T3	Nabam Rebia 2016	Governor's discretion narrow
T4	NJAC case 2015	judicial independence basic
T5	Vishaka 1997	guidelines in a legislative vacuum
T6	Sita Soren 2024	no privilege for bribes
T7	Kihoto 1992	Speaker as a reviewable tribunal
T8	L. Chandra Kumar 1997	tribunals under HC review
T9	Vineet Narain 1997	CVC statutory; CBI insulated
T10	Puttaswamy 2017	privacy; proportionality
T11	Kesavananda 1973	basic structure
T12	Marbury v Madison 1803	US judicial review, the model contrasted
T13	ADR 2024	electoral bonds struck

VERDICT

Polity is **half of GS-II** every year. Four themes — **bodies, federalism, Parliament, rights** — carry nearly half (48%) of the 1,648 marks set since 2013, and seven themes are **hot** now. One spine (D-W-B-H-G-G-R-J), two or three lenses, an Article and a case, gains against gaps, a **three-part reform line** and a verdict: that is the whole method. Practise it until every hot theme takes three minutes.